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Hochschule Darmstadt
University of Applied Sciences

Information Technology & Society

Should Generative AI Be Strictly Prohibited in Academic Assignments?

Debate Position: PRO

Authors:

Georgios Karyos - (1142306)

Stylianos Georgiou - (1142305)

Lecturers:

Prof. Gammel Stefan

Dr. Hamed Shariat Yazdi

Fall Semester 2025 – 2026

1. Introduction: The Debate and the Purpose of Education

The rapid development and widespread availability of generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools have introduced a new and complex challenge to contemporary education. What initially appeared as a technological innovation designed to support productivity has quickly become a subject of academic and ethical concern, particularly in relation to student assignments. Universities and schools across the world are now confronted with an essential question: should generative AI be strictly prohibited in academic assignments? This question formed the basis of the debate examined in this essay and reflects a broader discussion about the role of technology within educational systems.

The increasing presence of generative AI in education has changed how students approach academic work. Tools capable of producing complete essays, solving complex problems, or generating functional code within seconds challenge the traditional role of assignments as instruments for learning and assessment. Educational literature consistently highlights that assignments are not merely tasks to be completed, but essential components of the learning process. They are designed to encourage critical thinking, reinforce understanding, and allow students to engage actively with course material through effort, reflection, and problem-solving (Mindko, 2023) [1]. When this process is replaced by automated generation, the educational value of assignments is fundamentally altered.

During the debate, our team supported the strict prohibition of generative AI in graded academic assignments. This position was not based on a rejection of technological progress, but on a concern for the integrity and purpose of education itself. While AI technologies undoubtedly offer advantages in many areas of daily life, their use in assessed academic work risks transforming learning into a process focused on results rather than understanding. Research on academic integrity further emphasizes that the misuse of generative AI poses serious challenges to honesty, fairness, and trust within educational environments (Alam et al., 2024) [2].

At the heart of this discussion lies a fundamental question: what is the true purpose of assignments? If assignments exist to develop knowledge, independence, and critical reasoning, then education must prioritise the learning journey over flawless outcomes. This essay builds upon the arguments presented during the debate to examine how generative AI affects learning, assessment, and academic values, and why strict prohibition in academic assignments is necessary to protect the core mission of education.

[1] https://bera-journals.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1111/bjet.13585

[2] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=u1mfecqZfP0

2. Defining Generative AI and Its Role in Academic Assignments

Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) refers to a class of advanced machine learning systems capable of producing human-like text, code, and other content based on patterns learned from large datasets [3]. Unlike traditional digital tools that assist specific tasks, generative AI systems such as large language models can compose entire essays, answer complex questions, and generate functional programming solutions

within moments. While these capabilities may appear beneficial at first glance, they present a fundamentally different interaction with academic work compared to conventional tools like calculators or search engines. Calculators support students by performing mathematical operations without replacing the underlying reasoning process, and search engines provide access to information that students must interpret and integrate themselves. Generative AI, on the other hand, can produce polished results that students often submit as their own without engaging in the cognitive processes that underlie deep learning and comprehension [4].

In academic settings, this difference transforms the nature of assignments from exercises in thought to acts of outsourcing. A student who uses generative AI to complete an assignment no longer participates in research, analysis, or synthesis; instead, they receive a finished product and often accept it with minimal reflection or understanding. This shift effectively replaces critical thinking with automated convenience, undermining the educational goals that assignments are meant to support. In doing so, generative AI does not merely assist learning but can replace the very thought processes it was meant to enhance, leading to superficial engagement rather than meaningful understanding. This conceptual distinction — assistance versus replacement — is crucial in evaluating the role that generative AI should be allowed to play in formal academic work.

[3] https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2666920X25001699

[4] https://ceur-ws.org/Vol-3879/AIxEDU2024_paper_36.pdf

3. Learning as a Process, Not a Product

While the definition of generative AI and its capabilities helps frame the issue, the deeper concern lies in how learning actually occurs and what students lose when AI replaces key parts of that process. Education is not simply about producing correct answers; it is fundamentally about engaging with material, grappling with uncertainties, and refining understanding through effort, failure, and reflection. Struggle is uncomfortable by nature, involving confusion, trial and error, revision, and sometimes even failure. These moments of difficulty are not obstacles to learning but central components of it, as they stimulate cognitive engagement, encourage critical thinking and ultimately build deeper mastery over a subject [5].

When generative AI is used to complete academic assignments, this essential learning process is disrupted. A student who allows AI to produce their work bypasses the very mechanisms that support intellectual growth. Rather than wrestling with concepts and synthesizing information, the student receives polished outputs without having invested the mental effort required to arrive at those results independently. In such cases, assignments become mere submission tasks: checkboxes to be completed rather than

opportunities for genuine understanding. This shift diminishes the developmental role of education and reduces learning to the act of turning in a product [6].

Without the struggle that characterizes authentic learning, students may advance through coursework while lacking substantive comprehension of material they are expected to master. The absence of cognitive effort in completing assignments creates a gap between surface performance and deep understanding, one that often becomes evident only in situations that demand true application of knowledge, such as exams, higher-level courses, or real-world professional tasks. As a result, generative AI's interference in the learning process weakens the educational foundation that assignments are meant to build.

[5] https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/20965311251367053

[6] https://www.mdpi.com/2227-7102/15/2/113

4. Dependency and the Loss of Independent Thinking

The removal of struggle from the learning process, as discussed in the previous section, does not merely reduce understanding in isolated instances; over time, it reshapes how students approach thinking itself. When generative AI is repeatedly used to complete academic assignments, students begin to submit work that they cannot fully explain or defend. Essays may appear coherent and sophisticated, yet students struggle to reproduce similar arguments independently. In technical subjects, students may submit code they cannot debug or modify, revealing a growing gap between apparent performance and actual competence. This pattern signals a shift away from active engagement toward passive reliance [7].

As this reliance becomes habitual, confidence in one's own abilities is gradually replaced by dependence on external systems. Rather than viewing challenges as opportunities for growth, students may increasingly see difficulty as something to be avoided or outsourced. Independent problem-solving, a fundamental academic and professional skill, weakens as students defer cognitive effort to automated tools. Educational research has long emphasized that autonomy and self-efficacy develop through repeated practice and reflection; when these experiences are removed, students lose not only skills but also trust in their own intellectual capabilities [8].

The long-term consequences of such dependency extend beyond individual assignments. Students accustomed to AI-generated solutions may struggle when faced with unfamiliar problems that require adaptation, reasoning, or explanation under pressure. This dependence becomes especially visible in examinations, advanced coursework, or real-world situations where AI assistance is unavailable or inappropriate. In this way, generative AI risks creating an illusion of competence that masks a fragile foundation of understanding. This erosion of independence directly

affects how achievement is measured and sets the stage for broader issues of fairness within academic assessment.

[7] https://ersj.eu/journal/3876

[8] https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/impactofsocialsciences/2025/10/17/are-we-teaching-students-ai-competence-or-dependence/

5. Fairness and the Meaning of Grades

The growing dependency on generative AI discussed in the previous section raises a broader ethical concern within academic assessment: fairness. Grades are intended to reflect a student's effort, understanding, and progress over time. When students engage honestly with assignments, they invest significant time in researching, writing, revising, and reflecting on feedback. This process not only strengthens understanding but also ensures that grades serve as meaningful indicators of learning. However, the use of generative AI introduces a fundamental imbalance into this system [9].

Students who rely on AI-generated solutions are able to complete assignments rapidly and submit work that appears polished and technically flawless. In contrast, students who complete assignments independently may submit work that includes imperfections but reflects genuine effort and learning. When both submissions are assessed equally—or when AI-generated work receives higher grades—the meaning of grades becomes distorted. Assessment shifts away from measuring understanding and effort and begins to reward access to shortcuts rather than intellectual engagement [10].

This distortion has serious consequences for academic motivation. When honest effort is not meaningfully distinguished from automated output, students who follow the rules may feel disadvantaged or discouraged. Over time, this can erode trust in the assessment process and create pressure to adopt the same shortcuts in order to remain competitive. In such an environment, grades lose their educational value and instead reflect who used more efficient tools rather than who learned more effectively. This breakdown in fairness inevitably leads to deeper concerns about academic integrity, as the boundary between acceptable assistance and dishonest representation becomes increasingly blurred.

[9] https://herdsa.org.au/herdsa-connect/can-generative-ai-be-fair-marker

[10] https://nachrichten.idw-online.de/2024/04/12/revolutionising-grading-iu-study-reveals-ai-potential-for-fairer-assessment

6. Academic Integrity and Trust in Education

The erosion of fairness in assessment inevitably leads to a deeper issue at the core of education: academic integrity. Assignments exist to demonstrate a student's individual

understanding, effort, and engagement with a subject. When a student submits work generated by artificial intelligence and presents it as their own, this fundamental purpose is undermined. Regardless of the quality of the output, the act represents a form of misrepresentation, as the submitted work no longer reflects the student's independent thinking or learning process [11].

From an ethical standpoint, the use of generative AI in graded assignments closely resembles established forms of academic misconduct such as plagiarism. While the source of the content differs, the principle remains the same: credit is claimed for work that was not personally created. Academic integrity frameworks emphasize honesty, responsibility, and transparency as essential values in education. When these principles are compromised, the legitimacy of assessment outcomes is called into question, weakening the credibility of academic qualifications and the educational system as a whole [12].

Beyond individual cases of misconduct, widespread AI use in assignments contributes to a systemic breakdown of trust between students and educators. Teachers rely on assignments not only to evaluate performance but also to understand how students think, where they struggle, and how instruction can be improved. When the authenticity of student work becomes uncertain, teachers may begin to view all submissions with suspicion. This atmosphere of distrust damages the educational relationship, shifting it from collaboration and guidance toward monitoring and enforcement. Such a shift further distances education from its developmental goals and sets the stage for examining the broader impact of generative AI on the role of teachers within the educational system.

[11] https://www.susqu.edu/currents/2025/03/17/artificial-intelligence-academic-integrity/

[12] https://www.qaa.ac.uk/docs/qaa/members/the-rise-of-artificial-intelligence-software-and-potential-risks-for-academic-integrity.pdf

7. Impact on Teachers and the Educational System

The breakdown of academic integrity discussed in the previous section has significant consequences not only for students, but also for teachers and the educational system as a whole. Assignments serve a dual purpose in education: they assess student performance and function as critical feedback tools for educators. Through student submissions, teachers can identify patterns of misunderstanding, evaluate the effectiveness of their instruction, and adjust lessons to better support learning. When assignments authentically reflect student thinking, they provide valuable insight into how knowledge is being developed within the classroom [14].

The use of generative AI in academic assignments compromises this feedback mechanism. When student work no longer represents individual understanding,

teachers lose a reliable source of information about student progress. AI-generated submissions can mask gaps in knowledge, making it difficult for educators to distinguish between genuine comprehension and automated output. As a result, assessment becomes less informative, and instructional decisions are made based on distorted data rather than actual learning needs [13].

This unreliability has direct consequences for students who require additional support. When assignments fail to reveal areas of difficulty, struggling students may go unnoticed and therefore miss opportunities for timely intervention. Over time, this weakens the responsiveness of the educational system and undermines its capacity to foster equitable learning outcomes. Teachers are placed in a position where they must either assume authenticity or adopt a posture of suspicion toward all student work, further straining the educational relationship. These systemic challenges highlight the necessity of addressing AI use not only as an individual choice, but as an institutional issue that requires clear policies and collective responsibility.

[13] https://arxiv.org/pdf/2506.23815?

[14] https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1468033.pdf

8. The Role of Schools and Institutional Responsibility

The systemic challenges outlined in the previous section make it clear that the issue of generative AI in academic assignments cannot be resolved through individual student choice alone. Educational institutions carry both a moral and academic responsibility to define the boundaries within which learning and assessment take place. Schools and universities are not merely spaces for knowledge transfer; they are institutions that shape values such as honesty, responsibility, and fairness. When new technologies disrupt established educational practices, it is the role of institutions to respond with clear guidance rather than leaving students to navigate ethical decisions independently [15].

Relying on individual discretion in the use of generative AI creates inconsistent standards and undermines fairness. Students vary in their understanding of what constitutes acceptable assistance, and without explicit rules, the pressure to gain competitive advantage may push even well-intentioned students toward unethical behaviour. In such an environment, responsibility shifts unfairly onto individuals, while the system itself fails to provide the structure needed to support integrity. Clear institutional policies are therefore essential to ensure that all students are assessed under the same conditions and expectations [16].

Strict rules regarding the use of generative AI in graded assignments serve not as punitive measures, but as protective ones. They safeguard the meaning of assessment, preserve trust between students and educators, and reinforce the educational purpose of assignments. Without such boundaries, concepts such as fairness and honesty lose

their practical relevance, as enforcement becomes inconsistent and subjective. By establishing clear regulations, institutions affirm that learning, not efficiency or technological advantage, remains the primary goal of education. This institutional responsibility also extends beyond academic contexts, as the standards upheld within education directly influence how students approach responsibility and competence in real-world professional settings.

[15]https://educationaltechnologyjournal.springeropen.com/articles/10.1186/s41239-019-0171-0

[16]https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/17439884.2020.1798995#d1e142

9. Real-World Consequences and Professional Competence

The responsibility of educational institutions to preserve meaningful assessment becomes even clearer when considering the consequences beyond the classroom. Education does not exist in isolation; it functions as a preparatory system for professional and societal roles that require competence, responsibility, and independent judgment. When assignments and evaluations no longer accurately reflect a student's understanding, education risks certifying individuals who possess credentials without the skills those credentials are meant to represent [19].

A commonly used hypothetical scenario illustrates this concern clearly. Imagine discovering that a medical doctor completed significant portions of their education by relying on generative AI to pass assignments or examinations. While such a scenario may appear extreme, the discomfort it provokes highlights a crucial point: the issue is not the presence of technology itself, but whether education reliably measures readiness for real responsibility. In professions where decisions directly affect human lives, competence cannot be simulated or outsourced. Skills must be developed through rigorous training, practice, and demonstrated understanding [18].

This logic extends beyond medicine to numerous fields, including engineering, law, education, and information technology. When educational systems fail to ensure that learners genuinely master foundational knowledge, the consequences may not be immediately visible. Instead, gaps in understanding often emerge later, under pressure, when individuals are required to solve problems independently or make high-stakes decisions. At that point, it is no longer the educational system that bears the cost, but society as a whole.

By allowing generative AI to replace meaningful assessment, education risks shifting from a system that verifies competence to one that merely distributes qualifications. This distinction between credentials and capability is critical. If education ceases to serve as a reliable indicator of readiness, trust in professional standards erodes, and the long-term integrity of institutions is compromised. These concerns invite deeper

reflection on the role of technology in shaping not only learning outcomes, but also professional identity and human responsibility in an increasingly automated world [17].

[17] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qpoRO378qRY

[18] https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240029200

[19]https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/education/articles/10.3389/feduc.2024.1470979/full

10. Humanity, Perfection Culture, and the Meaning of Effort

The real-world implications discussed in the previous section invite a broader reflection on how generative AI is reshaping not only education, but also our expectations of human performance. One of the most profound cultural shifts introduced by AI in academic contexts is the normalization of flawless outcomes. Assignments generated or refined by AI often appear polished, error-free, and stylistically consistent, creating an implicit standard of perfection. Over time, this risks redefining what is considered acceptable or even expected student work [21].

Historically, mistakes have played a central role in learning. Errors, revisions, and moments of uncertainty were understood as natural steps toward understanding. In contrast, the widespread availability of generative AI encourages the avoidance of imperfection. Students may feel compelled to submit work that appears “complete” and technically refined, even if it does not reflect their actual level of understanding. As a result, the learning experience becomes less about growth and more about presentation, shifting focus away from intellectual development toward external appearance.

This trend raises a deeper concern about what it means to remain human in an increasingly automated world. Education has traditionally served as a space where individuals develop judgment, resilience, creativity, and self-confidence—qualities that emerge through effort and engagement rather than efficiency alone. When perfection becomes the standard, the value of effort diminishes, and the human aspects of learning risk being overshadowed by algorithmic optimization. In such a context, success may no longer be defined by understanding or perseverance, but by the ability to produce flawless outputs with minimal personal involvement [20].

Reasserting the importance of effort over perfection is therefore essential. In a world where AI tools are pervasive, education must continue to emphasize human learning as a process shaped by curiosity, struggle, and reflection. Preserving this balance does not require rejecting technology altogether, but rather reaffirming the role of education in cultivating human capacities that cannot be replaced by automated systems. This perspective provides the foundation for a more balanced discussion of how AI might be used responsibly, without undermining the core values that education exists to protect.

[20] https://www.ted.com/talks/sal_khan_how_ai_could_save_not_destroy_education

[21] https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S1041608023000195

11. AI as a Tool Versus AI as a Shortcut

The reflections on humanity and effort in the previous section make it clear that the debate surrounding generative AI in education is not about rejecting technology outright. Artificial intelligence already plays a meaningful role in everyday life, enhancing productivity, improving access to information, and supporting complex tasks across numerous fields. From navigation systems to language translation and medical diagnostics, AI tools have become integrated into modern society in ways that are both beneficial and unavoidable. Acknowledging these advantages is essential in maintaining a balanced and realistic perspective [24].

However, the distinction between AI as a supportive tool and AI as a shortcut is critical. When used responsibly, AI can assist learning by offering explanations, suggesting resources, or helping students clarify concepts. In these cases, the student remains actively involved in the learning process, using the technology as a supplement rather than a substitute. The ethical problem arises when AI is used to complete academic assignments in place of the student, effectively bypassing the intellectual effort that assignments are designed to cultivate [23].

Drawing clear boundaries between acceptable assistance and inappropriate replacement is therefore necessary. Education relies on assessments to evaluate understanding, not efficiency. Allowing AI to generate full assignments undermines this purpose and compromises the integrity of learning outcomes [22]. By reinforcing the prohibition of generative AI in graded assignments, institutions can preserve the educational value of assessment while still permitting the responsible use of technology in non-assessed contexts.

This balanced approach avoids both extremes: uncritical acceptance of AI in all academic tasks and absolute rejection of technological progress. Instead, it recognizes that the value of education lies not in flawless outputs, but in the development of independent thinking, judgment, and competence. Establishing this distinction prepares the ground for a final reflection on why strict prohibition in assignments ultimately serves not to limit students, but to protect learning, fairness, and the long-term credibility of education.

[22] https://www.pnas.org/doi/10.1073/pnas.1821936116

[23] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oxZzoVp5jmI

[24] https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/library/ethics-guidelines-trustworthy-ai

12. Conclusion: Why Prohibition Protects Education

This essay has argued that the strict prohibition of generative AI in academic assignments is not an act of resistance against technological progress, but a necessary measure to protect the core purpose of education. Throughout the discussion, it has become evident that assignments are not merely tasks to be completed, but essential tools for learning, assessment, and the development of independent thinking. When generative AI replaces student effort in graded work, these functions are fundamentally undermined.

The analysis has shown that unrestricted use of AI in assignments weakens the learning process, promotes dependency, distorts grades, and erodes fairness. More importantly, it compromises academic integrity and breaks the trust that must exist between students, teachers, and educational institutions. As education ceases to reliably measure understanding, its ability to prepare individuals for professional and societal responsibilities is placed at risk. The long-term consequences of this shift extend beyond academic settings, affecting public trust in qualifications and professional competence.

At the same time, this position does not deny the value of artificial intelligence as a technological tool. AI has clear benefits in supporting productivity, access to information, and problem-solving in many areas of life. However, the distinction between assistance and substitution is crucial. Education must remain a space where effort, struggle, and imperfection are valued as integral parts of learning. Allowing AI to complete assignments on behalf of students replaces growth with convenience and understanding with appearance.

Ultimately, the debate is not about banning technology, but about safeguarding education as a human process. Strict prohibition in academic assignments ensures that success reflects genuine understanding, that fairness is preserved, and that learning remains meaningful. In a world increasingly shaped by artificial intelligence, protecting these values is not a limitation—it is a responsibility.